

cises whatever small functions he has. I would say that in this sense the idea which presided over the making of *Julius Caesar* was that of giving a modern man's vision of ancient Rome and of the feeling of a city alive and functioning. This was what prompted Mr. Houseman to have as "technical adviser" on the picture not an ancient historian or an archeologist but a person of Italian origin and education. The idea was that the atmosphere of Rome in 44 B.C. was closer to that of an Italian city of any period than to anything else, and that a person with such memories could perhaps be less useless than a more conventional kind of expert. One of my favorite pedagogical devices is to invite listeners to transpose the idea of time into terms of space and to imagine, lined up somewhere, about sixty or seventy people: the ones who stand elbow to elbow happen to know each other exceptionally well, usually have lived together for a good portion of their lives. Sixty or seventy is a relatively small number of people; closeness of habits and feelings can be easily assumed. Yet those few people, once we line them up in time instead of space, carry us all the way back to our ancient Roman forefathers.

Nevertheless, the feeling of surprise at finding the many-storied apartment house of Ostia or a Pompeian carpenter's hammer practically identical with the one used now by the upholsterer next door in Rome or Venice, can always be renewed with delight. This was the delight involved in working on research for *Julius Caesar*, and the basic assumptions of the research coincided with those of the producers of the film and with the idea that the city was to be imagined as a "lived-in" place. A brief sampling of introductory notes taking during that time may be appropriate:

... Rome was a fast-growing city, but we may assume that the general shape of its central sections had not changed from the time when it had been a small one, in the same manner as downtown Los Angeles doesn't substantially change even though important new buildings are added—especially official ones such as the Federal Building (corresponding to temples, curias, etc., in Rome's center).

The city was inhabited by, and therefore it reflected, an oligarchy

of nobles-magistrates on one side, engaged in violent and often vicious struggles for power and office, and on the other by common people like the artisans in the first scene of *Julius Caesar* or like the mutable citizens whom Brutus and Antony address after the murder. . . . The aristocratic dwelling and the slum could be close to one another.

... Rome was also a city of narrow streets, slums, dirty little taverns, peddlars, small squares with people yelling across at each other, etc. . . . The temples, theaters, curias, and generally the places like the Forum which were the scenes of the ruling classes' disputations, intriguing, display of pomp, legal fights, and finally of the dictator's murder, must not have looked merely like the official and venerated national sanctuaries but rather like places very much frequented and lived in—like markets, federal court-houses, or stock exchanges.

Books most typically consulted in this respect were the ones that describe the city and the minutiae of its life in that period or in times immediately near. Besides ancient authors like Horace or Martial, useful modern works included those of Friedländer, Carcopino, and the more recent *Vita Romana* by Paoli. For the innumerable questions of detail that might arise, ranging from weapons to specimens of hairdo, from street vendors and shopkeepers to military salutes, there were the standard encyclopedias, Pauly-Wissowa, and, more particularly, Daremberg-Saglio. This sort of research, whatever amount of it might be used, showed one crucial difference between scholarship and film making: while the former can afford to be vague in its results, the latter cannot. However uncertain the evidence, scanty the documents, and numerous the hypotheses, the decision had to be made as to how a piece of garment would be worn, a salute would be given, and so on. Sometimes the "exactly right" detail was found: the sign upon the door of the tavern in the opening scene, for instance, is authentic though probably about eighty years wrong. Sometimes the "expert" indulges in purely Platonic satisfactions: for instance, the words scribbled on the walls in the small Roman square where the film opens were correct in type and legitimate in contents, though the camera hardly caught them. These are only scattered examples. There are problems that come up suddenly during